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US Media: Data Tracker 1Q26

16 April 2026

This is our regular quarterly US Media Data Tracker product, which examines trends in viewership on TV, the most popular series/movies by streaming platform, catalogues, value for money, cable audiences, box office and sports viewership.

This report is intended solely for consumption by Can Cui

Key Insights From The Data

Netflix's Slate Still Looks Good But It Will Face Tough Comps in 2H26:

- **Netflix's share of the Top-20 shows dropped from 46% to 40% even as viewership continued to grow (+14% yoy).**
- While Netflix's share of releases is increasing in 2Q26 to **57%**, it has only **40%** of the Top-25 most-anticipated shows. Netflix is ramping production volumes to fill gaps. We reckon that its dominance in 4Q25 should not be extrapolated forward, even if Netflix held share over the past two years, as competition continues to rise with generally better-funded rivals.

WBD Continues to Win in Content Terms:

- **WBD dominated MovieMeter rankings across all titles**, and both TV shows and Movies in 1Q26, with *The Pitt S2* emerging as a multi-season blockbuster. Its Top-20 viewership grew **84%** this quarter. **PSKY is buying a healthy studio.**
- HBO Max launched in European markets driving it **to #2 global streaming** according to FlixPatrol.
- Combining WBD and Paramount creates a market with 4 main players (Disney, PSKY, Netflix, Amazon): What does Comcast do?

Content Production Is Ramping to Pre-Strike Levels; Competition Is Rising Once Again:

- **Titles in production accelerated in 1Q26** with the sector approaching the '23, pre-strike, peak production.
- **Paramount and WBD are lowering production** as they get ready to merge.
- With increasing margins, continued revenue growth and improved balance sheets, **the threat of heightened competitive intensity is a real risk, in our view.**

Nielsen's Measurement Changes Implies More Growth Ahead for Streaming:

- **Nielsen changed its panel sources and technology, delaying The Gauge data for March.** According to the WSJ, **the new measures put streaming share 6ppts lower (now 42%).**
- This creates issues in the future for yoy comps and makes linear ratings hard to extrapolate from. Notably, **Fox seems to have faced a tough comp and a sizeable ratings decline even with the boost to linear viewing from the methodology change.**

F1 Transition to Apple TV Had Higher Opener Viewing; Step Change in TKO's UFC Viewing With PSKY:

- **Australian GP US viewing above ESPN levels for the season opener.** With Bahrain/Saudi cancelled, **next test will be Miami GP, which is expected to be Apple's first FTA race**, competing with ABC broadcast last year. **Jury out on new F1 regs. viewing impact.**
- **UFC's CBS/Paramount+ debut brought a step-change in US viewership** – **~5m** avg. for numbered events vs. **1.5-2m** EPSN PPVs.

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Stock Take-Aways

Alphabet – BUY	YouTube share gains continued to stall even if reaching ATHs in viewership.
Amazon – BUY	Prime Video continues to outspend the competition and make in-roads in terms of hits.
Apple – BUY	Apple TV continues to apply the HBO playbook.
Comcast – SELL	Peacock gained 218bps of streaming share in February (likely NFL/Olympics driven) but structurally will have to find a solution beyond sports rights. *Super Mario Galaxy* was the box office hit of the quarter (>$600M on $100M budget).
Fox Corporation – BUY	Tubi's growth appears to have stalled for now. Fox News had a tough comp in 1Q26.
Formula One Group – BUY	Apple seems to be driving engagement growth for F1. Ticket prices increased above inflation. Attendance up +9% in 1Q26.
Netflix – Buy	*Stranger Things* final season carried another quarter for Netflix, but the pipeline now looks thinner, with management compensating via catalogue expansion.
Paramount Skydance – NEUTRAL	Sequentially worse quarter for Paramount+. Also a weak Box Office.
Roku – BUY	Roku channel continues to grow.
Sony Group – BUY	Looking like '26 on track to be a great year for the Pictures division with a strong slate.
The Walt Disney Company – SELL	Disney+ was down 7% and Hulu down 60% in Top-20 viewership yoy. Disney+ and Hulu are starting to ramp their catalogues once again.
TKO Group Holdings – NEUTRAL	UFC's CBS/Paramount+ debut brought a step-change in domestic viewership — ~5m average for numbered events vs. estimated 1.5-2m PPVs during the ESPN era.
Versant Media - SELL	Versant hard to extrapolate from Nielsen data given viewership metric changes. Rating benefited from Winter Olympics although limited economic effect (space rented by Comcast).
Warner Bros. Discovery - Neutral	The content winner in 1Q26, topping MovieMeter rankings in all categories. HBO Max grew 84% yoy in Top-20 viewership and now offers the best cost-per-hit at its price point. Launch in the UK, Germany, Italy resulted in #2 global streaming service per FlixPatrol data.

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Streaming Analysis

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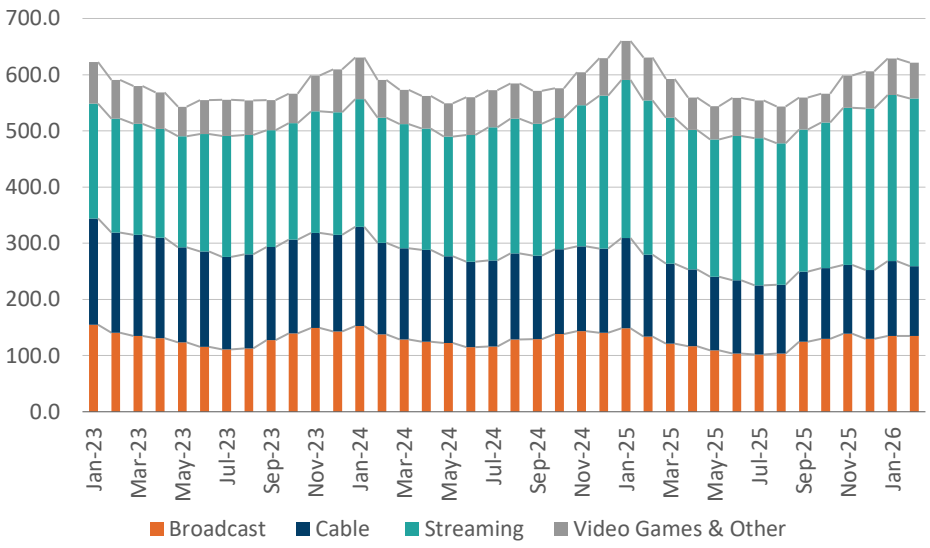
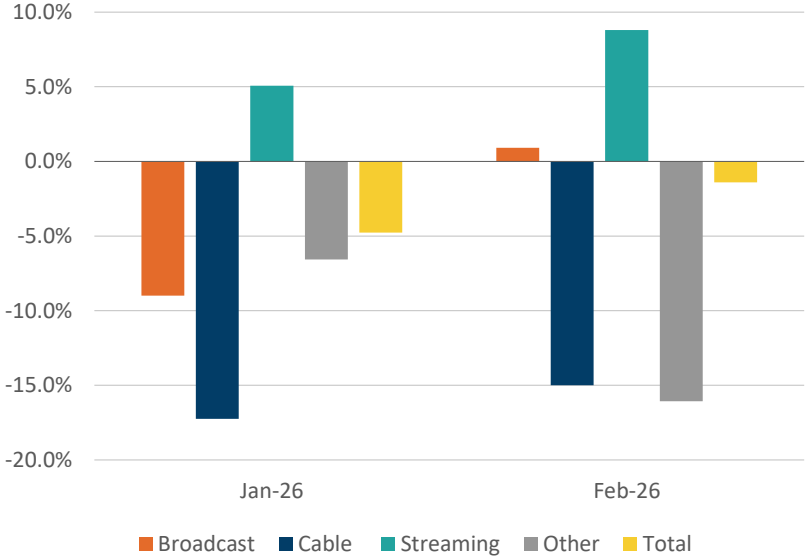
What's on US TV ?

Insights From The Gauge: Million Viewer Minutes per Medium (Left), Change YoY (Right)



Source: Nielsen, Arete Research.



Source: Nielsen, Arete Research.

- **Neilsen's methodology is changing** with adjustment to panel demographics and technology, expected to increase the **recorded linear audience by 6ppts rel. to streaming** (*WSJ*, Mar. '26). Data for Mar. '26 has been delayed and is not included in our report.
- The available data up until Feb. '26 is still based on Nielsen's old methodology, hence lfl comparisons are still valid.
- **Cable declines accelerated on a yoy basis** in both Jan. and Feb. '26.
- Broadcast grew **1%** yoy in Feb. after declining **9%** in Jan., averaging LSD declines despite the Winter Olympics, **pointing to a probable worsening of decline** vs. -3% in the prior year.
- **Streaming grew 5% in Jan. and 9% in Feb.** These are much lower growth rates than seen in the corresponding month in '24 and '25.
- **Overall TV viewership was down 5% in Jan. and 1% in Feb.**

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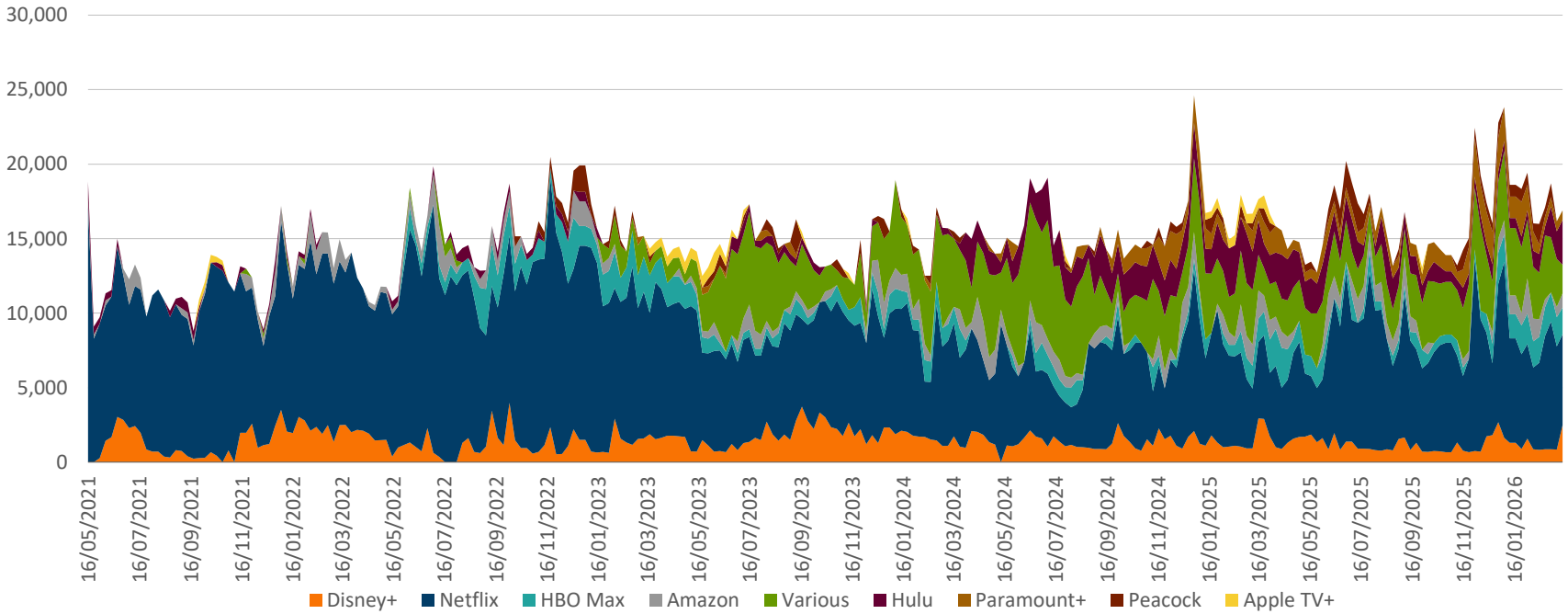
Which Platform Got The Hits?

Million Viewer Minutes per Platform per Week, Top-20 Nielsen Shows (US)



Source: Nielsen, Arete Research.

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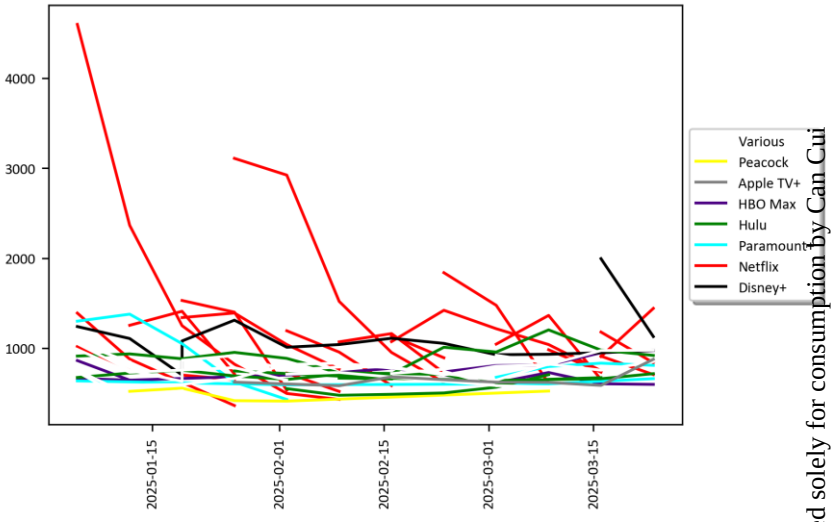
- **Aggregate Top-20 viewership was +6% yoy in 1Q26,** continuing to grow at a similar pace to recent quarters.
- **Netflix's share dropped from 46% in 4Q to 40% in the first 11 weeks of 1Q26 after an exceptional year-end slate, with Top-20 viewership +14% yoy in absolute terms.**
- **HBO Max, Paramount+ and Peacock continued to grow rapidly (+84%, +53%, +73%, respectively, yoy).**
- Hulu and Disney+ were down **50%** and **7%,** respectively, **continuing to underperform**.

Which Streamer Has The Top Shows?

Top-20 Shows Organised by Platform: Spotlight 1Q26 (Million Minutes P2+)

Title (Platform)	Rank	Minutes (m)
Stranger Things (Netflix)	1	20740
Bridgerton (Netflix)	2	12763
The Pitt (Max)	3	11100
Bluey (Disney+)	4	9811
The Big Bang Theory (Max)	5	8493
The Lincoln Lawyer (Netflix)	6	7479
Landman (Paramount+)	7	7441
Law & Order (Hulu/Peacock)	8	6614
Grey's Anatomy (Hulu/Netflix)	9	6609
SpongeBob SquarePants (Paramount+)	10	6218
Fallout (Amazon)	11	6171
The Traitors (Peacock)	12	5974
The Night Agent (Netflix)	13	5738
The Closer (Netflix/Peacock/Pluto TV)	14	5542
His & Hers (Netflix)	15	5468
Family Guy (Hulu)	16	4919
Rizzoli & Isles (Netflix/Peacock/Pluto TV)	17	4342
Love Is Blind (Netflix)	18	3865
Paw Patrol (Netflix/Paramount+)	19	3507
Bob's Burgers (Hulu)	20	3173

Source: Nielsen, Arete Research.



Source: Nielsen, Arete Research.

- **Netflix had a mega-hit with the last season of *Stranger Things,* topping the charts for two quarters in a row.** However, Netflix only had 6 exclusives in the Top-20 vs. 9 in the prior quarter.
- **The remainder of viewing was fragmented,** although notably early data for 15 episode *The Pitt S2* is suggesting that it may turn into a valuable broadcast-like show for Warner Bros Television, given that the premiere was up >200% vs. last season.

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How Do Catalogues Compare?

Services, Catalogues and Consumer Price Per "Hit"

Platform	Catalogue	Hits	TV Shows	Movies	Streams	Quality	Download	Other Perks	Price
Ad-tier									
Netflix Standard With Ads	7,409	1,337	3,174	4,235	2720p	no		Mobile Games	$8.99
HBO Max Ad-Supported	3,605	1,050	1,692	1,913	21080p	no		Sports	$10.99
Disney+	2,292	439	821	1,471	44K	no			$11.99
Hulu	2,950	738	1,759	1,191	24K	no			$11.99
Disney Bundle	5,242	1,177	2,580	2,662					$12.99
Paramount+	1,583	385	635	948	34K	no		Sports	$8.99
Peacock	1,986	441	1,085	901	34K	no		Sports	$10.99
Standard									
Netflix Standard	7,645	1,372	3,228	4,417	21080p		100	Mobile Games	$19.99
HBO Max Ad-Free	3,605	1,050	1,692	1,913	21080p		30	Sports	$18.49
Disney+	2,292	439	821	1,471	44K	unlimited			$18.99
Hulu	2,950	738	1,759	1,191	24K		25		$18.99
Disney Bundle	5,242	1,177	2,580	2,662					$19.99
Paramount+	1,595	388	643	952	34K		25	CBS & Sports	$13.99
Peacock	1,986	441	1,085	901	34K		25	NBC & Sports	$16.99
Premium									
Netflix Ultimate	7,645	1,372	3,228	4,417	44K		100	Mobile Games	$26.99
Max Ultimate	3,605	1,050	1,692	1,913	44K		30		$22.99

Platform	Cost per Hit	LTM Hitrate	Arete Score
Ad-tier			
Netflix Standard With Ads	0.67c	18%	3.7
HBO Max Ad-Supported	1.05c	29%	3.6
Disney+	2.73c	19%	14.3
Hulu	1.62c	25%	6.5
Disney Bundle	1.10c	22%	4.9
Paramount+	2.34c	24%	9.8
Peacock	2.49c	22%	11.2
Standard			
Netflix Standard	1.46c	18%	8.1
HBO Max Ad-Free	1.76c	29%	6.0
Disney+	4.33c	19%	22.8
Hulu	2.57c	25%	10.3
Disney Bundle	1.70c	22%	7.6
Paramount+	3.61c	24%	14.8
Peacock	3.85c	22%	17.5
Premium			
Netflix Ultimate	1.97c	18%	11.0
Max Ultimate	2.19c	29%	7.5

Source: JustWatch, Various Press Sources, Arete Research. Arete Score: Lower = Better.

- **HBO Max now looks like the most competitive streamer when factoring cost per hit and hit rate (Arete Score, lower = better).**
- **Netflix continues to retain an absolute advantage measured in consumer cost per hit**, even taking into account the Mar. '26 US price rises.
- **Combining WBD and Paramount+ with the proposed merger of PSKY and WBD matches the Disney Bundle in scale terms,** and creates a more consolidated market dominated by three large streamers + Prime Video.
- **Peacock looks like the laggard** and seems like it still needs to work on long-term streaming viability beyond bunding sports rights, which we do not see as a sustainable source of competitive advantage.

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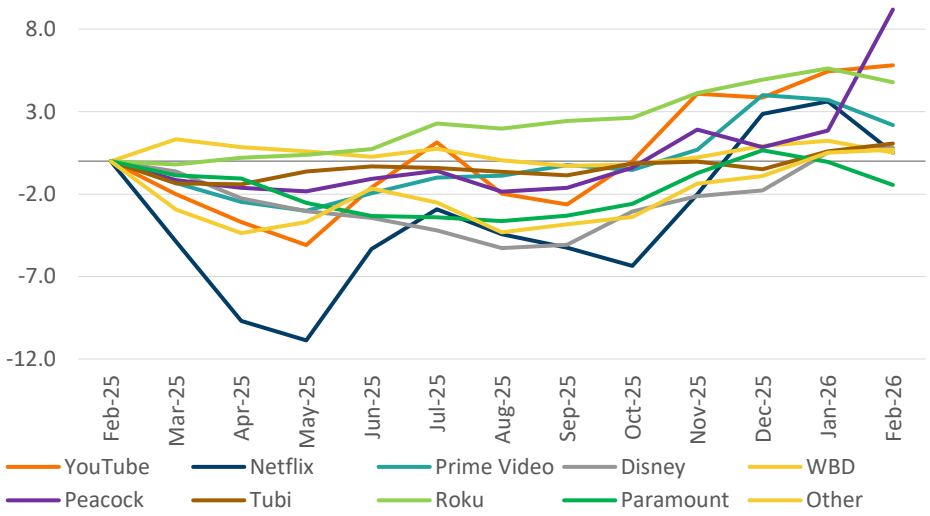
Total US Viewership Trends by Platform

Nielsen Incr. Av. Weekly Viewership (bn Minutes) Per Platform (Left), Shares of Streaming Viewership (Right)



Source: Nielsen, Arete Research.

Date	Nov-25	Dec-25	Jan-26	Feb-26	
YouTube (ex-TV)	*27.74%*	*26.68%*	*26.48%*	*26.51%*	*-123bps*
Netflix	*17.85%*	*18.91%*	*18.64%*	*17.54%*	*-31bps*
Prime Video	*8.17%*	*9.03%*	*8.69%*	*8.14%*	*-3bps*
Disney	*10.11%*	*9.87%*	*10.38%*	*10.44%*	*33bps*
WBD	*2.80%*	*2.94%*	*2.97%*	*2.71%*	*-8bps*
Peacock	*4.09%*	*3.57%*	*3.81%*	*6.26%*	*218bps*
Tubi	*4.52%*	*4.20%*	*4.45%*	*4.59%*	*8bps*
Roku	*6.24%*	*6.30%*	*6.36%*	*6.05%*	*-18bps*
Paramount	*4.95%*	*5.25%*	*4.87%*	*4.38%*	*-56bps*
Other	*13.76%*	*13.94%*	*13.76%*	*13.55%*	*-19bps*

Source: Nielsen, Arete Research.

- **Netflix and YouTube lost share to Peacock,** likely due to Peacock showing both the NFL Super Bowl and Winter Olympics this quarter.
- Other player shares were relatively stable in the quarter.
- **In absolute terms, all platforms reached new highs, aside from Paramount, which had a very difficult 1Q25 comp.**
- **Roku and YouTube continue to grow viewership the fastest yoy.**

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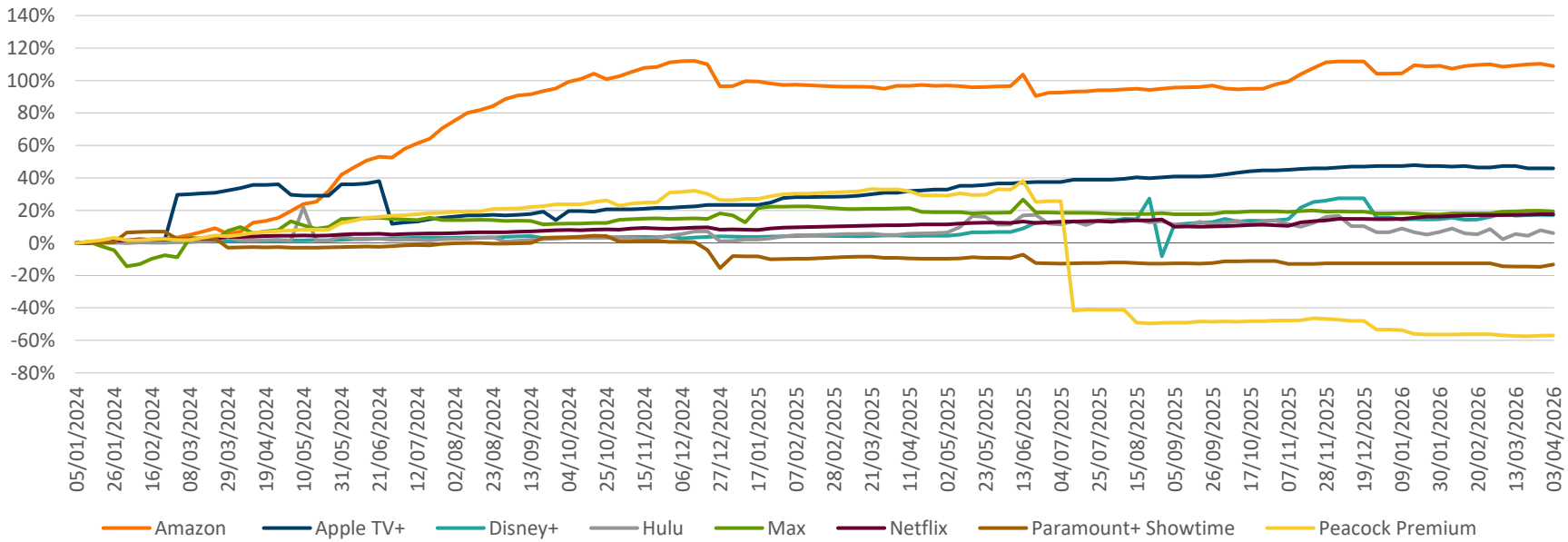
Catalogue Trends

Catalogue Growth by Streamer



Source: JustWatch, Arete Research.

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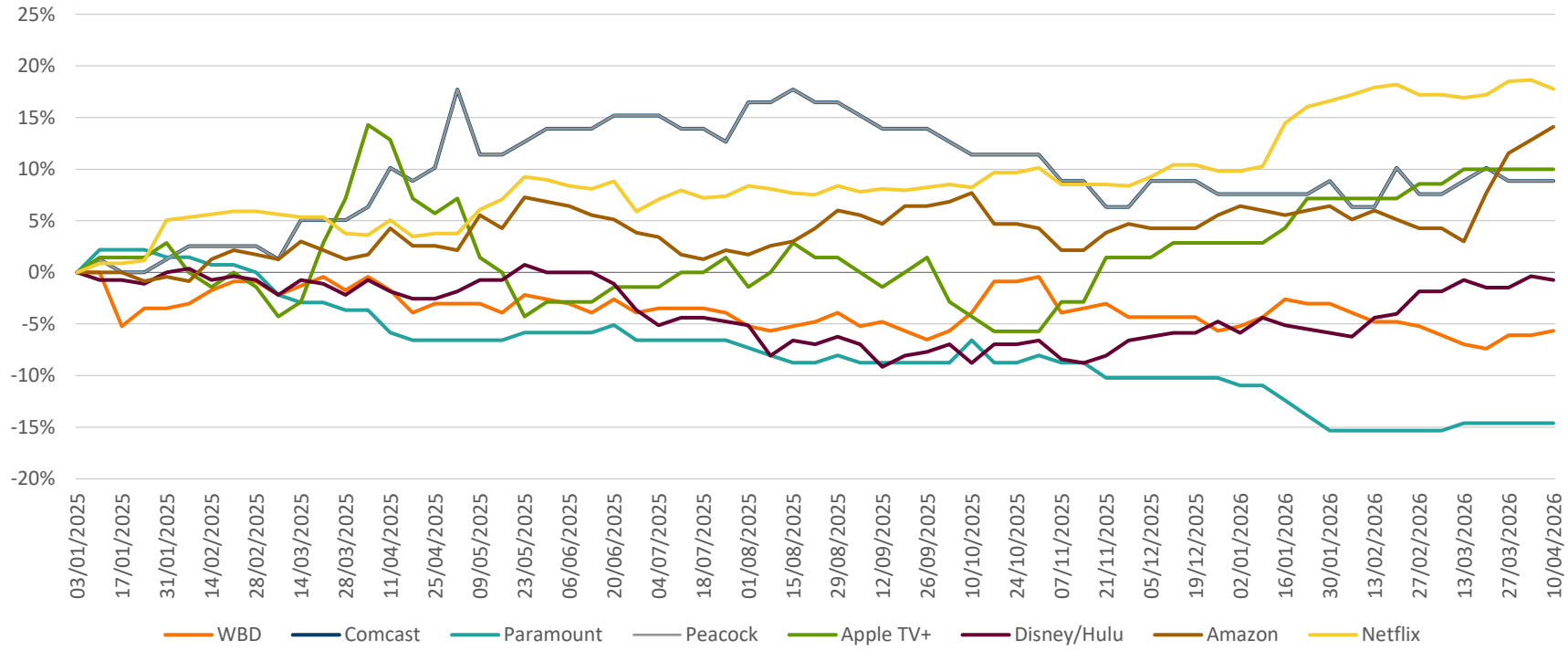
- **Peacock/Paramount continued to reduce their catalogues,** presumably making way for sports.
- Disney+ had a slight catalogue increase, while Hulu declined.
- **Amazon and Apple TV both grew their catalogues at an above market rate.**
- **Netflix accelerated catalogue growth** during the quarter, presumably to try to offset very difficult yoy slate comps in 2H26 (*Stranger Things* final series, *Squid Game S3*, *Knives Out 3*, etc., in '25).
- Other platforms' catalogues tended to be relatively stable.

Streaming Projects in Development

Projects in Development and in Production



Source: IMDB, Arete Research.

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- **Titles in Production accelerated** in 1Q26 from Disney/Hulu, Amazon, Netflix, Apple TV+, and Peacock, **driving the sector towards its pre-strike '23 peak** (1,863 vs. 1,837 as of 10 Apr.).
- **Paramount, WBD have reduced as they prepare to merge.**
- **Competition seems to be intensifying once again.**

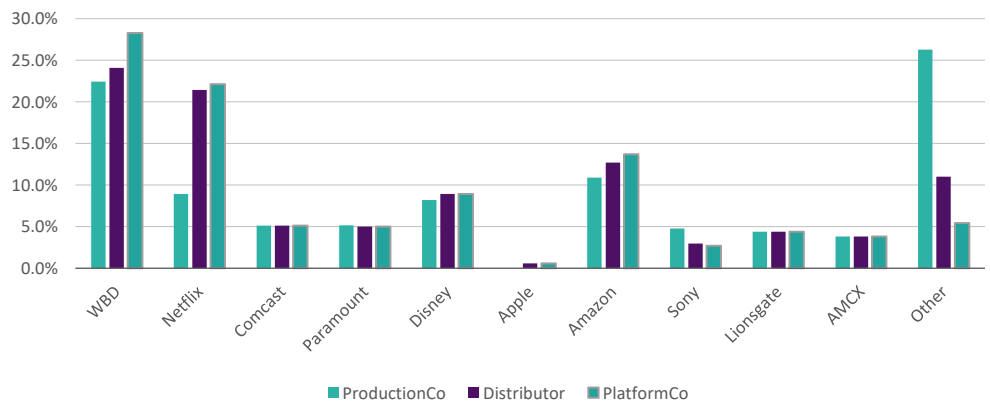
MovieMeter Rankings – All Titles

Most Successful Titles (MovieMeter 02 Jan. '26 – 27 Mar. '26)

Title	MovieMeter Rank Points (/325)	Rank	ProductionCo	Distributor	PlatformCo
The Pitt (2025–)	198	1	WBD	WBD	WBD
The Housemaid (2025)	186	2	Lionsgate	Lionsgate	Lionsgate
A Knight of the Seven Kingdoms (2026–)	176	3	WBD	WBD	WBD
Marty Supreme (2025)	168	4	Other	Other	WBD
One Battle After Another (2025)	154	5	WBD	WBD	WBD
Fallout (2024–)	150	6	Amazon	Amazon	Amazon
Stranger Things (2016–2025)	136	7	Netflix	Netflix	Netflix
The Rip (2026)	125	8	Other	Netflix	Netflix
Sinners (2025)	123	9	WBD	WBD	WBD
Hamnet (2025)	115	10	Comcast	Comcast	Comcast

Source: Arete Research based on IMDB MovieMeter ranking.

Platform Rankings (MovieMeter 02 Jan. '26 – 27 Mar. '26)



Source: Arete Research based on IMDB MovieMeter ranking.

- **WBD came top this quarter on all metrics, continuing to highlight the value of its content.**
- *The Pitt S2* stands out as WBD's newest hit.
- **Netflix came a close second**, while other legacy MediaCos had a weak quarter.

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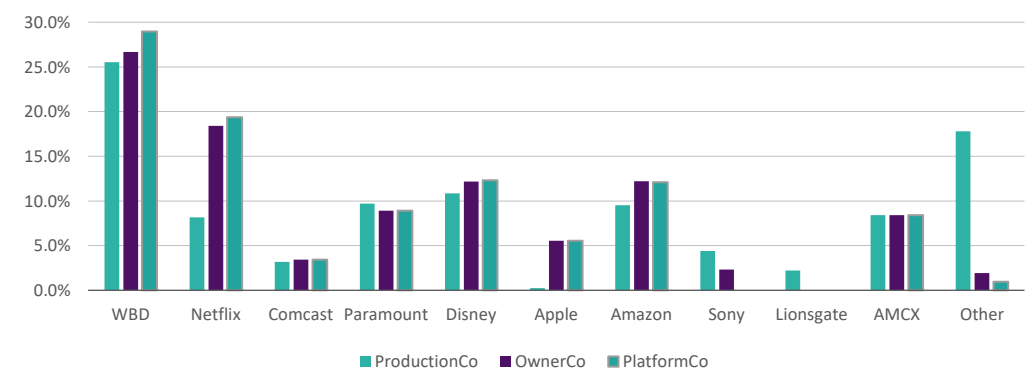
Spotlight on TV Shows

Most Successful TV Shows (MovieMeter 02 Jan. '26 – 27 Mar. '26)

Title	MovieMeter Rank Points (/325)	Rank	ProductionCo	Distributor	PlatformCo
The Pitt (2025–)	288	1	WBD	WBD	WBD
A Knight of the Seven Kingdoms (2026–)	263	2	WBD	WBD	WBD
Game of Thrones (2011–2019)	216	3	WBD	WBD	WBD
Stranger Things (2016–2025)	202	4	Netflix	Netflix	Netflix
Fallout (2024–)	199	5	Amazon	Amazon	Amazon
Breaking Bad (2008–2013)	189	6	AMCX	AMCX	AMCX
The Night Manager (2016–)	167	7	AMCX	AMCX	AMCX
Heated Rivalry (2025–)	166	8	Other	WBD	WBD
Landman (2024–)	150	9	Paramount	Paramount	Paramount
Bridgerton (2020–)	121	10	Other	Netflix	Netflix

Source: Arete Research based on IMDB MovieMeter ranking.

Platform Rankings (MovieMeter 02 Jan. '26 – 27 Mar. '26)



Source: Arete Research based on IMDB MovieMeter ranking.

- **WBD won in TV shows,** with the Top-3 shows of the quarter from a MovieMeter perspective.
- **Netflix only had two top shows, with its ranking down from the prior quarter.**
- It looked like a weak quarter for other MediaCos.

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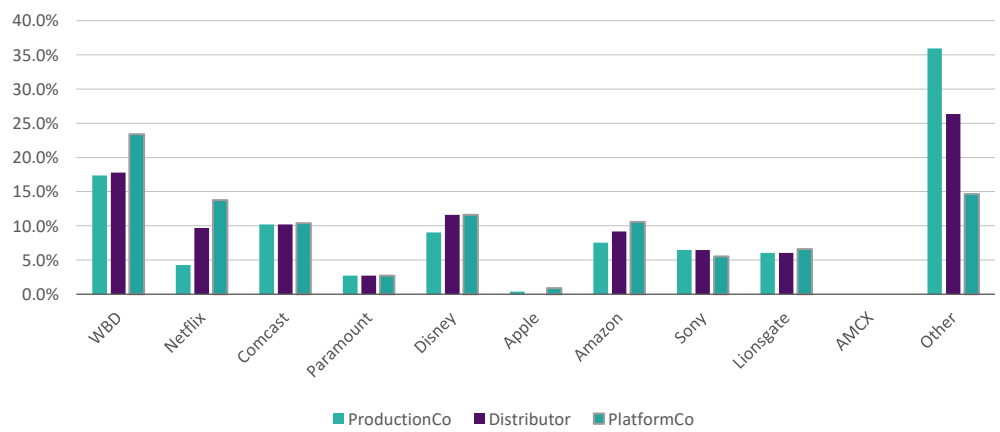
Spotlight on Movies

Most Successful Movies (MovieMeter 02 Jan. '26 – 27 Mar. '26)

Title	MovieMeter Rank Points (/325)	Rank	ProductionCo	Distributor	PlatformCo
Marty Supreme (2025)	254	1	Other	Other	WBD
The Housemaid (2025)	249	2	Lionsgate	Lionsgate	Lionsgate
One Battle After Another (2025)	245	3	WBD	WBD	WBD
Sinners (2025)	216	4	WBD	WBD	WBD
Hamnet (2025)	213	5	Comcast	Comcast	Comcast
The Rip (2026)	158	6	Other	Netflix	Netflix
Bugonia (2025)	147	7	Comcast	Comcast	Comcast
Wuthering Heights (2026)	138	8	WBD	WBD	WBD
28 Years Later: The Bone Temple (2026)	123	9	Sony	Sony	Sony
Send Help (2026)	92	10	Disney	Disney	Disney

Source: Arete Research based on IMDB MovieMeter ranking.

Platform Rankings (MovieMeter 02 Jan. '26 – 27 Mar. '26)



Source: Arete Research based on IMDB MovieMeter ranking.

- **1Q26 was a relatively unimportant box office quarter, lacking in high-budget releases.**
- Most of the movies topping the MovieMeter came from late '25.
- **WBD continues to perform very well in Movies.**

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2Q26 Release Schedule

Top-25 Planned Releases of 2Q26 Ranked by MovieMeter

Rank	Title	MovieMeter	Platform	Date
1	Masters of the Universe	27	Amazon	04-Jun
2	BEEF (Season 2)	102	Netflix	16-Apr
3	Turn of the Tide (S3)	196	Netflix	10-Apr
4	Thrash	248	Netflix	10-Apr
5	Cape Fear (Season 1)	257	Apple TV	05-Jun
6	Dutton Ranch (Season 1)	265	Paramount+	15-May
7	Hacks (S5)	328	HBO Max	09-Apr
8	Stranger Things: Tales from '85 (Season 1)	432	Netflix	23-Apr
9	The Dark Wizard (S1)	459	HBO Max	14-Apr
10	The Sheep Detectives	469	Amazon	07-May
11	APEX	503	Netflix	24-Apr
12	Margo's Got Money Troubles (Season 1)	650	Apple TV	15-Apr
13	Big Mistakes (S1)	725	Netflix	09-Apr
14	Widow's Bay (Season 1)	735	Apple TV	28-Apr
15	The Miniature Wife (S1)	804	Peacock	09-Apr
16	Off Campus	822	Amazon	13-May
17	Outcome	842	Apple	10-Apr
18	Spider-Noir (Season 1)	982	Amazon	27-May
19	Avatar the Last Airbender (Season 2)	1242	Netflix	25-Jun
20	Star City (S1)	1283	Apple	29-May
21	Rivals (Season 2)	1345	Hulu	15-May
22	Running Point (Season 2)	1600	Netflix	23-Apr
23	Sugar (Season 2)	2143	Apple TV	19-Jun
24	Man on Fire (Season 1)	2248	Netflix	30-Apr
25	Tom Clancy's Jack Ryan: Ghost War	2367	Amazon	20-Jun

Source: Arete Research based on IMDB MovieMeter ranking, flixpatrol.com

- **Netflix has ramped releases, leading to a 57% share of planned releases in 2Q26, up from 43% in 4Q.**
- **Other platforms also lowered planned releases,** notably Paramount and HBO Max.
- **Netflix has 10 out of the Top-25 releases** (i.e., 40%), which is not especially high relative to the past. **Netflix still seems to be pursuing quantity**, while others seem to be more focused on quality.

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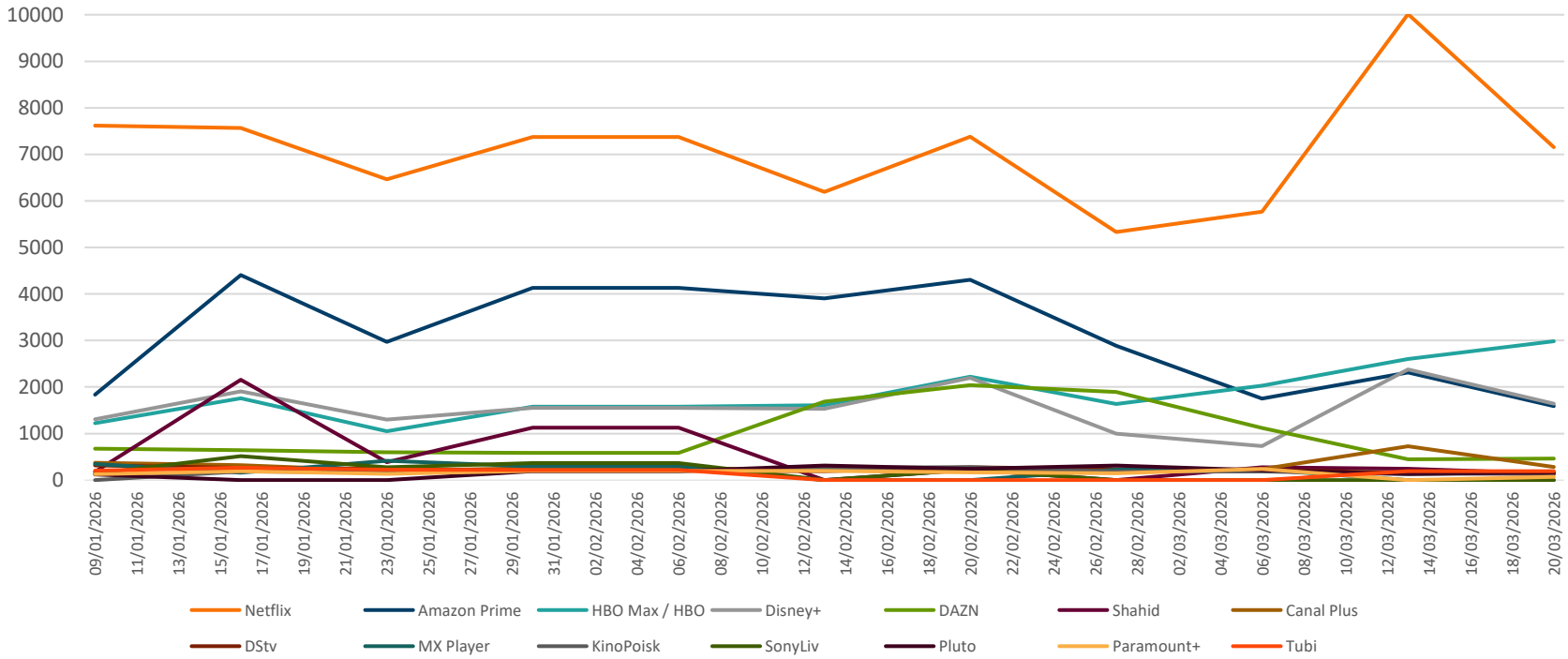
International Streaming Data

International Streaming Services App Ranking, weekly (09 Jan. '26 – 20 Mar. '26)



Source: FlixPatrol.

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- **Netflix** remains the top service in most countries around the world. As was evident in US data, it took share around the world, too.
- **HBO Max took the #2 spot, boosted by international launches in the UK, Germany and Italy.**

Linear and Sports Analysis

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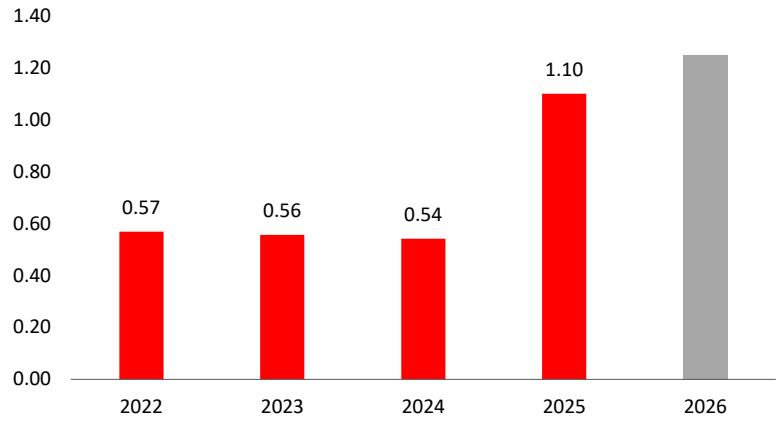
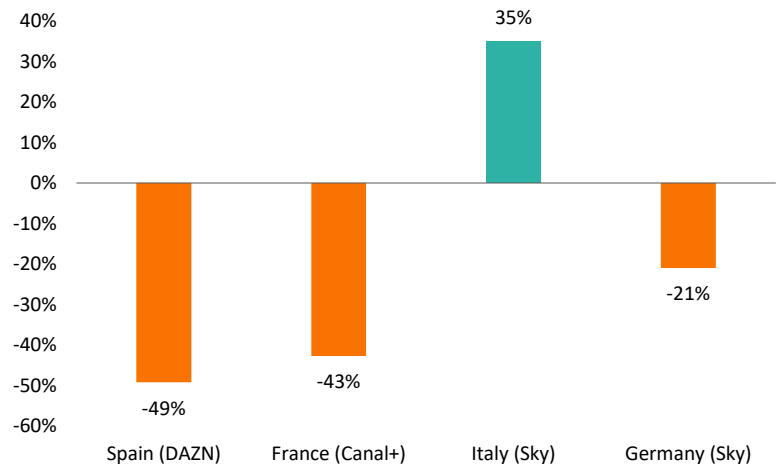
1Q26 F1 Viewership Trends

Apple Viewership Surpasses ESPN for Opener



Source: Nielsen for historic ESPN viewership and Apple for commentary on '26 Australian GP.

Japanese GP Viewership Mixed in Europe



Source: European media outlets, Formula1 God and thejudge13.com.

- **Australian GP US viewership figures suggests that concerns around the potential for lower engagement on Apple TV were misplaced:**
  - Apple's Eddy Cue confirmed that **Apple's opening race viewership exceeded ESPN's 1.1m viewership (Nielsen).**
  - Both '25 and '26 Australian GPs were "season openers" and **so seem to us like a fair lfl comparison**.
  - **Apple TV seems to be supporting US engagement growth** vs. concerns about F1 races going behind Apple's paywall.
- **Expect the Miami GP (4 May) to be the first "free-to-air" race on Apple TV, likely heavily marketed,** and providing the first comparison vs. ABC broadcast viewership last season.
- Recent media reports (e.g., gpfans.com) suggest that **European viewership has been "mixed" given the new regulations** (e.g., Japan GP – lower chart).
- **Too early to judge the impact of new regulations on viewership,** given the planned regs evolution over the season. **There have more overtakes, but fans are critical of battery deployment vs. driver skill overtaking** ("Mario Kart racing"), with notable driver dissatisfaction (e.g., Verstappen). **Key also will be whether Mercedes dominates the field**.
- From an economic perspective, **there is plenty of time for F1 to respond with regs adjustments given 5-7 years of contracted revenues.**
- **Iran conflict resulted in cancellation of Bahrain and Saudi GPs.**

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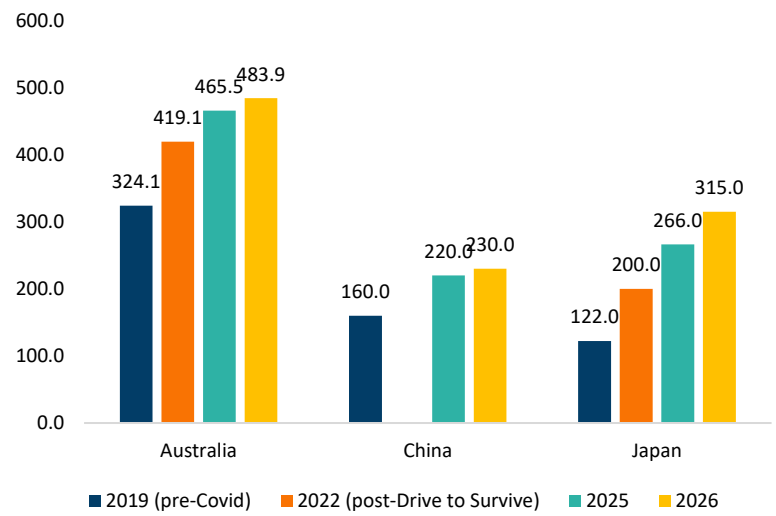
F1 GP Attendance & Ticket Prices

F1 Race Attendance & Ticket Price Growth

Formula 1 GP	Race attendance		Ticket prices	P x Q
	vs. '25	vs. pre-Covid	vs. '25	vs. '25
Australia	*+4.0%*	*+49.3%*	*+8.2%*	*+12.5%*
China	*+4.5%*	*+43.8%*	*+14.0%*	*+19.2%*
Japan	*+18.4%*	*+118.0%*	*-1.6%*	*+16.5%*
ytd average	***+9.0%***	***+70.4%***	***+6.9%***	***+16.1%***

Source: F1 GP hosting organisations, Statista, F1Destinations.com, Arete Research.

F1 1Q26 Weekend Race Attendance (000s)



Source: F1 GP hosting organisations, F1Destinations.com.

- We set out in *F1 Ecosystem Update ('26 ed.)* (Jan. '26) how we see **F1 being in the midst of an accelerated race promotion cycle** as new and renewed contracts land **across '25-'27E.**
- **Race promoter economics continue to result in intense competition to host GPs and to bring higher fees.**
- **F1 race attendance increased 9% yoy in 1Q** vs. '25 and is up **>70%** vs. pre-Covid levels.
- **Ticket prices increased significantly ahead of inflation,** with the Japanese GP decline reflecting ¥-depreciation vs. $ (data is in $).
- Chinese GP promoter took price for the first time since racing returned to the calendar in '24. **See a meaningful step-up in race fee for the new contract starting in '26.**
- **Race promotion revenues grew 15-20% yoy in 1Q26E, per our analysis.**
- On a 3-year view, **Australia/Japan promoter revs. increased +55%/+85%**, respectively, with contract extensions landing in '26/'25. Chinese promoter revs. are **up >25% vs. two years ago.**

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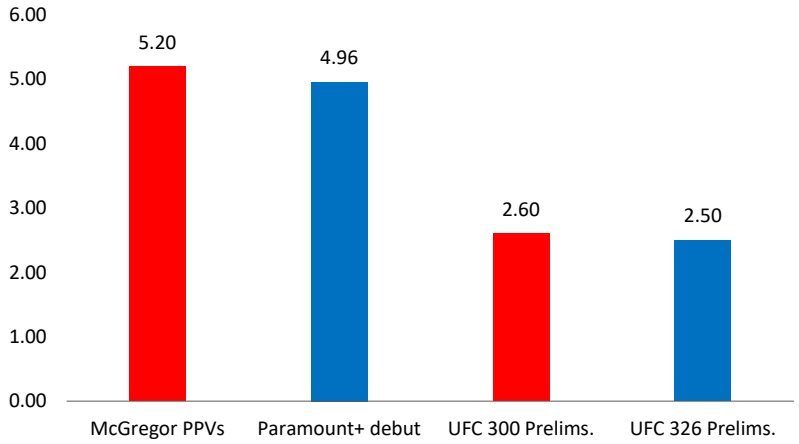
UFC Viewership and Numbered Event Gates

UFC Viewership Summary 1Q26 (millions)



Source: Nielsen, ESPN, Paramount and Sports Business Journal.

UFC *Numbered* Event Attendance & Gross Gate

From left to right:
Numbered event attendance; Gross gate implied average ticket price

1Q25				1Q26			
UFC 311	18,370	$10.2m	$555	UFC 324	19,480	$11.0m	$560
UFC 312	18,255	$7.7m	$420	UFC 325	18,100	$10.1m	$560
UFC 313	19,775	$15.0m	$760	UFC 326	19,480	$8.3m	$425
Total	**56,400**	**$32.9m**	**$585**		**57,060**	**$29.4m**	**$515**
% yoy growth					*1.2%*	*-10.9%*	*-12.0%*

Source: TKO Group and tapology.com.

- **UFC viewership is off to a strong start on CBS/Paramount+** for its new 7-year **$1.1bn** AAV rights agreement – this points to **meaningful sponsorship opportunity for UFC** on higher domestic viewership.
- Paramount reported **4.96m average viewership for its debut *numbered* fight event (UFC 324) on Paramount+** (n.b., Paramount+ has dropped PPV for *numbered* events in the US).
- This viewership across US and Latin America is **broadly comparable with "behind PPV paywall" global viewership for historic McGregor fights** (UFC's highest viewership fighter historically), assuming **3.5** viewers per PPV for McGregor fights (averaging **1.5m** PPVs/fight).
- With typical PPVs <500k in the ESPN era (= 1.5-2m domestic), **we think this points to a significant step-up for main card *numbered event* viewership in the US.**
- Expect viewership to taper/normalise slightly from the debut night, **as we saw with WWE's *Monday Night Raw* on Netflix.**
- **CBS "prelims" viewership looks similarly strong on debut** – UFC 326 prelims on CBS averaged **~2.5m** viewership in US, **comparable with ESPN's Apr. '24 high for UFC 300,** which was broadcast across ESPN, ESPN+ and Hulu SVOD.
- Lower table shows **Live Events** revenue trends in 1Q26. Expecting stable attendance for *numbered* events but slightly weaker ticket pricing. **The resulting low-teens decline implied for Live Events revenue is also reflected in consensus.**

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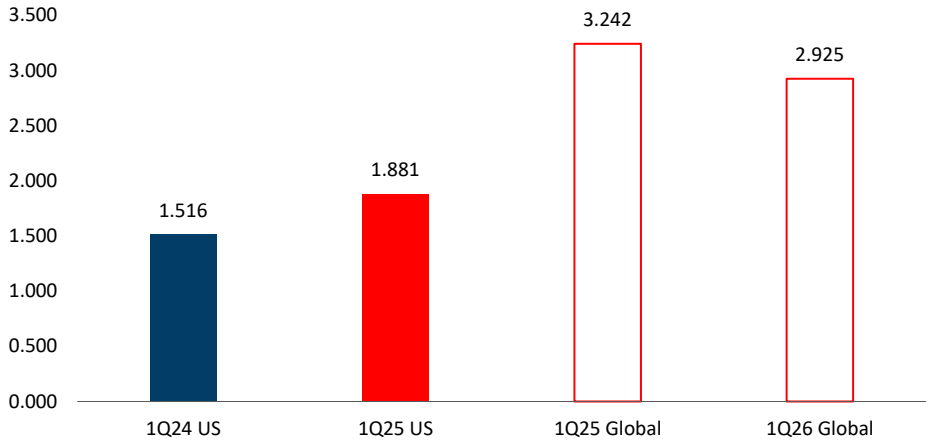
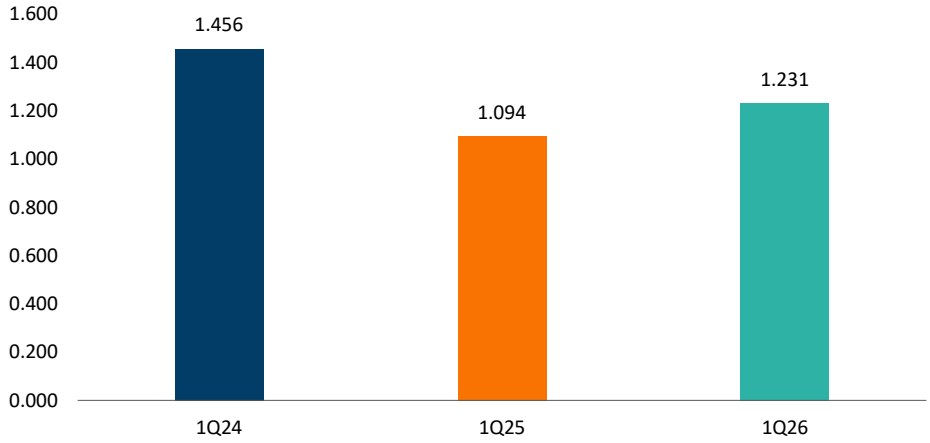
WWE Viewership Trends

1Q26 Monday Night Raw Viewership (millions)



Source: Nielsen, USA Network, Nielsen/VideoAmp ests. and Netflix.

1Q Friday Night Smackdown Viewership (millions)



Source: Nielsen, USA Network, Wrestlenomics.

- **Monday Night Raw premiered on Netflix on 6 Jan. '25,** having previously aired on *USA Network*.
- After a strong 1Q25 (**1.9m** average US viewership), Netflix *Raw* viewership trended lower, settling at **~1.5m** per show, **broadly consistent with prior cable viewership.**
- Can access global household viewership **when *Raw* hits a Top 10 Netflix ranking:**
  - **Global *Raw* viewership fell ~10% yoy in 1Q26.**
  - Only 4 *Raw* shows made the Top-10 vs. 12 in 1Q25.
- Lower chart shows ***Friday Night Smackdown* viewership on USA Network.**
  - *Smackdown* viewership grew **12.5%** yoy in 1Q26.
  - **Remains structurally lower than it was on *Fox Sports* in 1Q24.**

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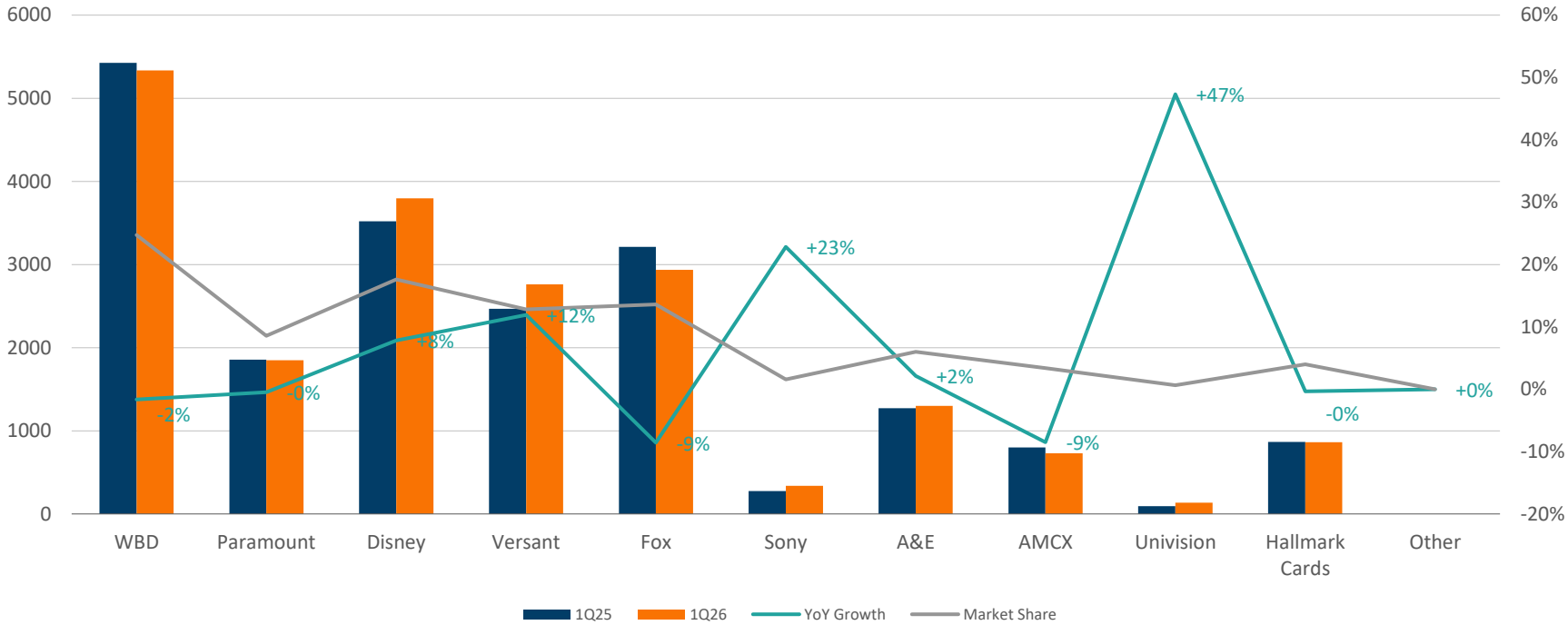
How Are Cable Audiences Trending?

Quarterly Cable Audience by MediaCo (Average Qly Audience, Prime Time, P2+ Viewers 000s)



Source: USTVDB, Arete Research.

- While Neilsen didn't adjust their streaming data, they did adjust linear data for the new panel demographics and technology. **This resulted in a sizeable increase in stated linear viewing, which cannot be adjusted in the orange historical data in the chart above.**
- **Hard to take too much from this data, other than it is wrong to assume that, for example, Versant's rating was +12% yoy !** Worth noting that while Versant viewership benefited from the Winter Olympics, Comcast retained the bulk of the Olympics economics, simply renting space on USA Network.
- **Worth noting that Fox seems to have had a weak quarter** (-9% on non-lfl data) given a difficult post-election comp in 1Q25.
- Market share variations between the cable networks looked relatively minor in the scheme of historical data.

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The Box Office

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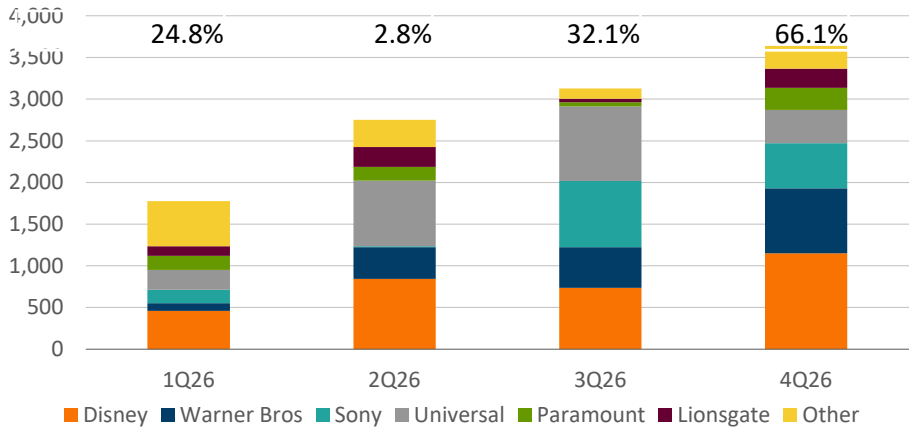
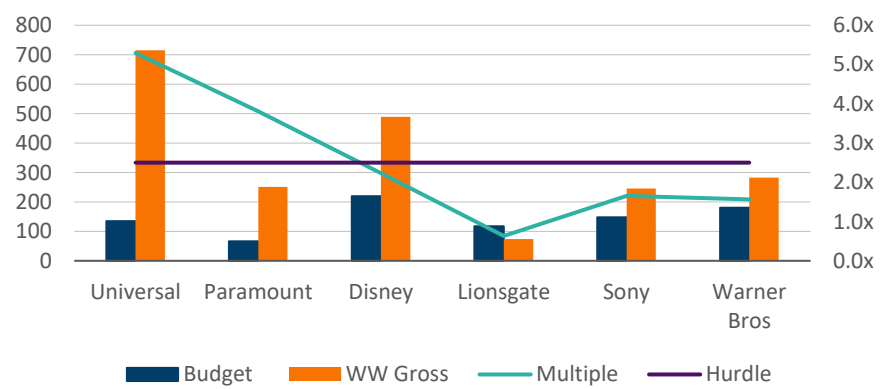
Box Office Performance & Outlook

Qtly. Domestic Box Office Projections and Growth



Source: IMDB, The Numbers, Arete Research estimates.

4Q25 WW Gross vs. Budget by Distributor



Source: IMDB, The Numbers, Arete Research estimates.

- **North American Box Office receipts were up +25% yoy in 1Q26.** This was despite a weak slate from majors as independent studios picked up the slack.
- **This quarter was a good quarter for Comcast, driven by *Super Mario Galaxy* grossing >$600m so far against a $100m budget.**
- Overall, Box Office is performing above expectations driven by independent Studios and **Comcast having the only hit movie, and likely a profitable quarter.**

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Key Insights

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Stocks Mentioned in This Report

Company	Ticker	Share price	Rating	Price Target	Implied Upside
Alphabet	GOOG-US	$337	Buy	$405	*+20%*
Amazon	AMZN-US	$249	Buy	$285	*+14%*
Apple	AAPL-US	$266	Buy	$305	*+15%*
Comcast Corp.	CMCSA-US	$28.30	Sell	$23	*-18%*
Formula One Group	FWONK-US	$90.47	Buy	$125	*+38%*
Fox Corporation	FOXA-US	$63.66	Buy	$97	*+52%*
Netflix	NFLX-US	$108	Buy	$116 (previously $110)	*+8%*
Paramount Skydance	PSKY-US	$11.67	Neutral	$14	*+17%*
Roku	ROKU-US	$109	Buy	$133	*+22%*
Sony Group Corp	6758-JP	¥3,402	Buy	¥5,570	*+64%*
The Walt Disney Company	DIS-US	$103	Sell	$77	*-25%*
TKO Group	TKO-US	$193	Neutral	$185	*-4%*
Versant Media	VSNT-US	$41.00	Sell	$36 (previously $33)	*-12%*
Warner Bros. Discovery	WBD-US	$27.20	Neutral	$31.25	*+15%*

Source: Arete Research, FactSet for share prices (as of 15 Apr. '26).

- **We increase our price target for Netflix to $116 in '26E (previously $110)** as a result of factoring-in late-March price increases, currency impact, and other minor estimate adjustments. Our price target is based on a 50/50 blend of multiples (average of forward multiples in '27E – 27.5x P/E, 30x P/FCF, 22.5x EV/EBITDA – discounted back to YE'26E) and DCF (WACC 8.5%/PGR 3%).

- **We increase our price target for Versant to $36 in '27E (previously $33)** as a result of factoring in 4Q25 results. Our price target remains based on 3.5x EV/EBITDA in '27E, less net debt in '27E, divided by YE27E share count assuming buybacks.

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Key Insights From The Data

Netflix's Slate Still Looks Good But It Will Face Tough Comps in 2H26:

- **Netflix's share of the Top-20 shows dropped from 46% to 40% even as viewership continued to grow (+14% yoy).**
- While Netflix's share of releases is increasing in 2Q26 to **57%**, it has only **40%** of the Top-25 most-anticipated shows. Netflix is ramping production volumes to fill gaps. We reckon that its dominance in 4Q25 should not be extrapolated forward, even if Netflix held share over the past two years, as competition continues to rise with generally better-funded rivals.

WBD Continues to Win in Content Terms:

- **WBD dominated MovieMeter rankings across all titles**, and both TV shows and Movies in 1Q26, with *The Pitt S2* emerging as a multi-season blockbuster. Its Top-20 viewership grew **84%** this quarter. **PSKY is buying a healthy studio.**
- HBO Max launched in European markets driving it **to #2 global streaming** according to FlixPatrol.
- Combining WBD and Paramount creates a market with 4 main players (Disney, PSKY, Netflix, Amazon): What does Comcast do?

Content Production Is Ramping to Pre-Strike Levels; Competition Is Rising Once Again:

- **Titles in production accelerated in 1Q26** with the sector approaching the '23, pre-strike, peak production.
- **Paramount and WBD are lowering production** as they get ready to merge.
- With increasing margins, continued revenue growth and improved balance sheets, **the threat of heightened competitive intensity is a real risk, in our view.**

Nielsen's Measurement Changes Implies More Growth Ahead for Streaming:

- **Nielsen changed its panel sources and technology, delaying The Gauge data for March.** According to the WSJ, **the new measures put streaming share 6ppts lower (now 42%).**
- This creates issues in the future for yoy comps and makes linear ratings hard to extrapolate from. Notably, **Fox seems to have faced a tough comp and a sizeable ratings decline even with the boost to linear viewing from the methodology change.**

F1 Transition to Apple TV Had Higher Opener Viewing; Step Change in TKO's UFC Viewing With PSKY:

- **Australian GP US viewing above ESPN levels for the season opener.** With Bahrain/Saudi cancelled, **next test will be Miami GP, which is expected to be Apple's first FTA race**, competing with ABC broadcast last year. **Jury out on new F1 regs. viewing impact.**
- **UFC's CBS/Paramount+ debut brought a step-change in US viewership** – **~5m** avg. for numbered events vs. **1.5-2m** EPSN PPVs.

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Stock Take-Aways

Alphabet – BUY	YouTube share gains continued to stall even if reaching ATHs in viewership.
Amazon – BUY	Prime Video continues to outspend the competition and make in-roads in terms of hits.
Apple – BUY	Apple TV continues to apply the HBO playbook.
Comcast – SELL	Peacock gained 218bps of streaming share in February (likely NFL/Olympics driven) but structurally will have to find a solution beyond sports rights. *Super Mario Galaxy* was the box office hit of the quarter (>$600M on $100M budget).
Fox Corporation – BUY	Tubi's growth appears to have stalled for now. Fox News had a tough comp in 1Q26.
Formula One Group – BUY	Apple seems to be driving engagement growth for F1. Ticket prices increased above inflation. Attendance up +9% in 1Q26.
Netflix – Buy	*Stranger Things* final season carried another quarter for Netflix, but the pipeline now looks thinner, with management compensating via catalogue expansion.
Paramount Skydance – NEUTRAL	Sequentially worse quarter for Paramount+. Also a weak Box Office.
Roku – BUY	Roku channel continues to grow.
Sony Group – BUY	Looking like '26 on track to be a great year for the Pictures division with a strong slate.
The Walt Disney Company – SELL	Disney+ was down 7% and Hulu down 60% in Top-20 viewership yoy. Disney+ and Hulu are starting to ramp their catalogues once again.
TKO Group Holdings – NEUTRAL	UFC's CBS/Paramount+ debut brought a step-change in domestic viewership — ~5m average for numbered events vs. estimated 1.5-2m PPVs during the ESPN era.
Versant Media - SELL	Versant hard to extrapolate from Nielsen data given viewership metric changes. Rating benefited from Winter Olympics although limited economic effect (space rented by Comcast).
Warner Bros. Discovery - Neutral	The content winner in 1Q26, topping MovieMeter rankings in all categories. HBO Max grew 84% yoy in Top-20 viewership and now offers the best cost-per-hit at its price point. Launch in the UK, Germany, Italy resulted in #2 global streaming service per FlixPatrol data.

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Primary Analyst(s) Coverage Group: AT&T, Autostore Holdings, BT Group, Charter Communications, Cipher Digital, Comcast, Coreweave, Core Scientific, Deutsche Telekom, DraftKings, Flutter Entertainment, Formula One Group, Fox Corporation, Genius Sports, HUT 8, IREN, Liberty Global, Nebius Group, Netflix, Ocado Group, Orange, Paramount Skydance, RIOT Platforms, SoftBank Group Corp., Sportradar, Sunrise Communications, Symbotic, Telecom Italia, Telefonica, TKO Group Holdings, T-Mobile US, TeraWulf, Verizon Communications, Versant Media, Vodafone, Walt Disney Company, Warner Bros. Discovery.

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